
”Nourished Among the Foremost Men”: An Inquiry into Grosseteste’s Intellectual Background

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Abstract

The scholarly debate has long struggled with Bishop Robert Grosseteste’s biography. His early life and intellectual formation remain unclear, and the scarcity of sources makes this biographical deadlock quite impossible to overcome. Yet, scholarship recognizes this gap as a fundamental breach for a clear understanding of Grosseteste’s thought.

Few sources provide information on Grosseteste’s life before 1235. But some of them seem to have been cruelly overlooked. The reason is that, taken individually, they do not reveal much, but read together across several corpora, they may help us identify possible figures involved in Grosseteste’s intellectual formation and shed new light on his intellectual network.

The ongoing progress in data management allows researchers to interpret sources with a new extent. Our article thus intends to exploit these tools in order to map his intellectual influences. To do so, we will use sources ranging from episcopal acts and abbey chronicles to the chronicles of Matthew Paris or Salimbene, as well as the letters of Adam Marsh and Robert Grosseteste. Moreover, various abbey cartularies provide valuable information on the theologian’s interactions with the regular orders. We hope by the end of this investigation to identify the eminent men mentioned by Grosseteste when referring to his intellectual training.

In doing so, it might shed light on new lines of inquiry regarding digital humanities in general and Robert Grosseteste’s studies in particular.

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